

Secondary and Incidental Findings in Genetic Testing

The National Society of Genetic Counselors strongly advises pre-test counseling that facilitates informed decision-making, elicits patient preferences regarding secondary and/or incidental findings if possible, and formulates a plan for returning such results before testing occurs.

Germline and somatic genetic testing, in both clinical and research contexts, may identify secondary findings and incidental findings as a part of the test performed. **Secondary findings** are purposely analyzed as part of the test, but unrelated to the primary testing indication. **Incidental findings** are detected unexpectedly during the analysis, and also unrelated to the primary testing indication. Both of these types of variants may be disclosed as a part of the return-of-results process.

The pre-test counseling process should establish clear expectations for what categories of results will and will not be returned. Healthcare practitioners conducting the informed consent and return-of-results processes for broad genomic testing and screening should ensure that their patients have access to practitioners with genetic expertise, such as genetic counselors. (Adopted 2015; Revised 2020; Reaffirmed 2023)